Briscoe echoes this, unpacking this year's brand presentations at the prestigious Geneva-based Watches and Wonders show. "Rolex and Chopard reintroducing stone dials reflect the market rediscovering the niche, brands reaching for an audience that wants more than the mundane. Part of the desire is the uniqueness of the stone: no two are alike, each has a life of its own. The dial has always been the focal point of a watch, but lately it has become the picture in the picture frame. A stone dial carries an inherent sense of natural luxury and artistry that resonates differently than lacquer or metal, buyers are responding to wearable art. And sourcing them is genuinely difficult: selecting the right colour, the right movement in the stone, the right reflection, the same painstaking process a gemmologist follows for a jewel. That process deserves respect.

If coloured stones are having a moment in global horology, India has been speaking that language for centuries in its jewellery, textiles and architecture. The country's homegrown watch brand Titan—world's fifth-largest watchmaker by volume—combines precious stones like diamonds and rubies and hard stones like malachite and aventurine with top-notch horological craftsmanship in their luxury Nebula collection. Kalpana Rangamani, who heads Titan's premium and luxury watch segment explains: "India has always expressed beauty through colour. Today, that same celebration of colour is returning to global luxury, with coloured gemstones dominating jewellery collections and hard-stone dials emerging as one of the most exciting trends in high horology. Nebula's creations such as Jalsa and Amer sit squarely within this movement, drawing on India's position as the lapidary capital of the world, with centuries of expertise in cutting, polishing and setting gemstones. The result is a collection that is both distinctly Indian in spirit and completely aligned with the direction of modern luxury."

Unlike international brands, Titan showcases India's technical prowess by extending the use of gems and hardstones beyond dials. In the Nebula Jalsa Tourbillon, red agate is used as a dial and on movement decoration in the case's back. "The expertise required to slice red agate into thin slivers, and use them as decoration in the movement, is a reflection of our imagination, precision and craftsmanship," explains Rangamani.

Nebula's recent Amer collection uses aventurine and malachite to beautifully capture the emotions of a dreamer and victor respectively. "Our latest novelty unveiled in Geneva in April this year, is the Nebula Genesis Starburst. The bezel of this stunning watch is set with 60 diamonds, with each stone being custom cut and set in a flawless way."

At a time when luxury is increasingly defined by repetition, the appeal of gemstones and natural hardstones lies in their refusal to be identical. Each carries its own colour, inclusions, movement and geological history, qualities that cannot be perfectly replicated. Their return to watchmaking reflects a deeper shift in what collectors now value: not simply precision or prestige, but individuality, emotion and the quiet authority of something shaped by nature. In that sense, colour is not merely a trend; it is a response to the need of the hour, a desire for objects that feel personal, singular and truly alive.

● Piaget high jewellery cuff watch featuring an opal dial with diamond-set bezel and case



Photo by PIAGET